THE GREAT NI CONTROVERS

AS THE NATIONAL GREEN TRIBUNAL CLEARS THE ₹81,000 CRORE PORT AND DEFENCE PROJECT ON THE ISLAND, ENVIRONMENTALISTS FEAR THE LOSS IT WILL INFLICT ON ITS UNIQUE BIODIVERSITY

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UNDER THREAT

LEATHERBACK SEA TURTLE

The world's largest sea turtle, the leatherback (*Dermochelys coriacea*) can grow up to 2 metres in length and weigh over 600 kg. It gets its name from its fleshy carapace, which feels like leather: unlike other sea turtles, leatherbacks lack a hard shell. The Nicobar Islands host some 94 per cent of the nesting sites (1,000+) of this critically endangered species in the northeast Indian Ocean. Even small disruptions of light, noise and shoreline stability can threaten hatchling survival.

THE FEAR: Environmentalists cite Galathea Bay as a major nesting site. The area is classified as Coastal Regulation Zone (CRZ)-1A—an ecologically highly sensitive zone where construction activity is prohibited. They warn that the proposed installation of a port, which would require dredging millions of tonnes of sand and silt, could permanently damage these fragile habitats and severely disrupt turtle nesting grounds.

THE RESPONSE: According to the ministry of environment, forests and climate change (MoEFCC), a June 2023 expert-led 'ground-truthing' exercise found no part of the project falling in the CRZ-1A zone. The ministry has also proposed setting up a 13.75 sq. km leatherback turtle sanctuary and a 500-metre protected buffer around Pemayya on the western coast of Great Nicobar Island. Critical nesting beaches, including the western flank of Galathea Bay, Pemayya Bay, Alexandria Bay, Casuarina Bay and Dogmar, have been designated as strict no-development zones and will be under continuous surveillance during nesting and hatching seasons to ensure a 'zero-predation' strategy for turtle nests.

Photograph by ADHITH SWAMINATHAN